

Exploring Further Customizations

You can customize VS Code in many ways to help you work more efficiently. To start exploring the customizations available, click **Code** and then **Preferences**, and then choose **Settings**. You'll see a list titled Commonly Used; click any of the subheadings to see some common ways you can modify your installation of VS Code. Take some time to see if there are any that make VS Code work better for you, but don't get so lost in configuring your editor that you put off learning how to use Python!

VS Code Shortcuts

All editors and IDEs offer efficient ways to do common tasks that everyone needs to do when writing and maintaining code. For example, you can easily indent a single line of code or an entire block of code; you can just as easily move a block of lines up or down in a file.

There are too many shortcuts to describe fully here. This section will share just a few that you'll likely find helpful as you're writing your first Python files. If you end up using a different editor than VS Code, make sure you learn how to do these same tasks efficiently in the editor you've chosen.

Indenting and Unindenting Code Blocks

To indent an entire block of code, highlight it and press CTRL-], or ⌘-] on macOS. To unindent a block of code, highlight it and press CTRL-[, or ⌘-[on macOS.

Commenting Out Blocks of Code

To temporarily disable a block of code, you can highlight the block and comment it so Python will ignore it. Highlight the section of code you want to ignore and press CTRL-/, or ⌘-/ on macOS. The selected lines will be commented out with a hash mark (#) indented at the same level as the line of code, to indicate these are not regular comments. When you want to uncomment the block of code, highlight the block and reissue the same command.

Moving Lines Up or Down

As your programs grow more complex, you may find that you want to move a block of code up or down within a file. To do so, highlight the code you want to move and press ALT-up arrow, or Option-up arrow on macOS. The same key combination with the down arrow will move the block down in the file.

If you're moving a single line up or down, you can click anywhere in that line; you don't need to highlight the whole line to move it.

Hiding the File Explorer

The integrated file explorer in VS Code is really convenient. However, it can be distracting when you're writing code and can take up valuable space on a smaller screen. The command CTRL-B, or ⌘-B on macOS, toggles the visibility of the file explorer pane.